

Ava Pace

My Key Insight Summer Internship Experience

This past summer, between my Junior and Senior year, I was accepted into an internship position at Empire Eats Catering in Raleigh, North Carolina. The internship taught me a mixture of different skills while having me do many different types of jobs, including but not limited to, collecting data on internal practices and comparing the data to similar companies, using Canva to personalize our customer facing paperwork, managing the warehouse space, and even working the company food truck. While all of these different tasks were incredible experiences, what really stuck with me throughout this summer internship is when I was given a leadership role of overseeing the Ross Pavilion at the UNC Health Championship Golf Tournament hosted at Raleigh Country Club.

Empire Eats Catering was chosen as the caterer for this golf tournament, including two VIP areas, a Tito's sponsored tent, and various concession spots including our food truck. I oversaw one of these VIP areas, the Ross Pavilion, which guests needed to buy a more expensive one day ticket for access. What made this seating area most desirable was the multitude of rotating fans, the shade and elevated seating, the open bar, and, of course, the buffet that would be themed after a different Empire Eats owned restaurant each day.

It took an army to successfully pull off this event, with a multitude of staff at each area as well as runners who would consistently make sure every area had enough cups, ice, liquor, and more. I had the pleasure of having a bar tender and banquet server on my team each day. Of course, with the amount of food the banquet server had to handle, there were many times I would throw on a pair of latex gloves and help out to make sure we were consistently working

in a timely manner. Throughout the four-day tournament me and my staff were able to pull off four successful banquet services.

The point of this experience was not only for Empire Eats Catering to put their name out there, but also to bring attention to the restaurants under the Empire Eats name. Empire Eats is a company that owns seven different restaurants in the Downtown Raleigh area, each preserving the original architecture of the buildings they reside in. Greg Hatem, the owner of the company, has been one of the biggest forces behind the development of the downtown Raleigh area. Catering this tournament not only reminded many Raleigh residents of our many restaurants, but bolstered the image of our company as a professional, efficient, and, of course, delicious catering service.

This experience was huge in my development in taking leadership roles. While I have led many projects in my academics in the past, this was my first time leading a team to complete a task with a much bigger outcome than just a letter grade. There were many times throughout this four-day tournament that I struggled with what to do, what steps to take to fix a problem, and even how I should lead a team with two staff members that have more experience than I do working for Empire Eats Catering. While some mistakes were definitely made, I learned how to roll with the punches, for example, we were missing a side dip one of our days that we would not be able to get until the buffet had been open for an hour. Rather than panicking, we put out larger servings of the other two dips offered on that day's buffet menu and took away the sign that would indicate the spot of our missing dip.

Leadership can be difficult, because if you lead your staff wrong, or if a staff member goes against your lead and makes a mistake, the blame will fall to their leader, especially in the

field of hospitality. I believe that the biggest two things I learned about leading a team is that there will be times you need to get your hands dirty as well to make sure an event goes smoothly, and that when there is a mistake that can't be fixed immediately, own up to it rather than hiding from it.

If I worked as a cashier and my manager had no idea how to do my job if something happened and we needed an extra set of hands, I would not have faith in that manager. That's why, throughout this tournament, when lines got long and food needed replenishing, I was there helping rather than just delegating. Delegation is important, but so is making sure we are doing our job efficiently and professionally, that is why I would help wherever I could whenever one of my staff was in the weeds.

While we never made a mistake that was unfixable throughout the tournament, there was a time I made a bad call about ice, for example, and we were close to needing to shut down the bar temporarily until we received more. Thankfully one of our runners had an extra bag when they were nearby that we were able to snag, but that doesn't change the fact that my call of believing we had enough when they were distributing ice earlier almost led to a disaster. Once the day slowed down, despite the crisis being averted, I apologized to my bar tender and took responsibility of how my call caused unneeded stress and almost negatively impacted their ability to do their job. When you take accountability, your staff will trust you and your calls much more in the future.

I believe that this experience not only taught me how to be a true leader, but also what separates a good leader from a bad leader. It has helped me in trusting my gut when making choices and owning up when the wrong choice is made. It has taught me that making a wrong

choice is better than over deliberating and refusing to make a choice. It has taught me that being a leader doesn't make you above the work your employees do. Finally, it has taught me to listen to my team, whether more or less experienced, because a different perspective can be the difference between a smooth event and disaster. I now have full confidence in my future in the workplace as either a staff member or as a leader, now knowing what it takes to be successful in either role.